

May 24, 2026

Professor Matthieu Guitton, PhD
Editor-in-Chief
Computers in Human Behavior
Laval University
Québec City, Québec, Canada

Dear Professor Guitton,

We submit the original research article “Help Converts Newcomers, Not Veterans: Generalized Reciprocity and Platform Engagement on Stack Overflow” for consideration as a research report in *Computers in Human Behavior*.

The paper examines whether receiving help on an online platform increases subsequent helping behavior. Using a matched difference-in-differences survival analysis of more than 21 million questions from Stack Overflow, we find that receiving an answer increases the hazard of later helping by roughly 6% overall, but the effect is strongest among newcomers and disappears among the most experienced users. Response time moderates the effect non-linearly: reciprocity peaks when answers arrive 30–60 minutes after a question is posted, consistent with a platform re-engagement mechanism. We believe this work fits naturally within the journal’s *Cyberbehavior* area on human behavior in virtual spaces, as it examines how computer-mediated help-seeking and help-giving shape cooperation on a large online platform.

We believe the manuscript will interest readers working on online communities, prosocial behavior, knowledge sharing, and the human consequences of platform design. The study contributes new field evidence on generalized reciprocity and offers actionable implications for contributor recruitment on question-and-answer platforms.

This manuscript is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration elsewhere. All authors have approved the submission. The attached files include a title page with author details, an anonymized manuscript, highlights, and a declaration of competing interests, in accordance with the journal’s double-anonymized review requirements.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Lenard Strahringer

Corresponding Author
Stanford University
lenardst@stanford.edu
On behalf of Sven Eric Pruess and Kai Riemer